

Lavrov: Washington is setting up an army in Syria with the involvement of terrorists

The United States has begun creating an anti-government armed organization in Syria with the involvement of fighters from the Islamic State terrorist organization, Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov said during a meeting with his Turkish, Syrian and Iranian counterparts in Moscow on Wednesday.

"The goal is clear - to use these fighters against the legitimate authorities of the Syrian Arab Republic, to destabilize the situation in the country," Lavrov said, opening the three-hour meeting, according to the RIA Novosti news agency.

In addition to Lavrov, the meeting was attended by Turkish Foreign Minister Mevlut Cavusoglu, Syrian Foreign Minister Faisal Mekdad, and Iranian Foreign Minister Hossein Amirabdollahian.

The head of Russian diplomacy said that the Americans plan to involve representatives of other terrorist organizations and local Arab tribes in the new anti-government armed formation to be formed around Raqqa. He recalled that the defense ministers of the four countries recently discussed this problem in Moscow and agreed to take joint countermeasures.

The Russian state news agency TASS recalled that in February, the Russian Foreign Intelligence Service (SVR) reported that the United States was training fighters of jihadist groups affiliated with the Islamic State terrorist organization at the al-Tanf base in Syria to carry out terrorist attacks in Russia and other CIS countries.

Lavrov proposed developing a roadmap at the expert level by the next meeting of the foreign ministers of the two countries to settle Syrian-Turkish relations. He said that the heads of state would be informed about the details of the plan.

According to the Russian Minister of Foreign Affairs, all participants in the quadrilateral meeting agree that the document should enshrine the

sovereignty, territorial integrity, independence and unity of all countries, as well as their commitment to the purposes and principles of the UN Charter. He also called ensuring the safe and voluntary return of Syrian refugees a key task supported by the parties.

“We are all interested in the early restoration of good-neighborly relations between Syria and Turkey, based on the principle of equality and mutual benefit,” said the minister, who complained that Western sanctions were hindering aid shipments to Syria.

He praised the close cooperation between the partners in the “uncompromising fight against terrorism and terrorist organizations in all their manifestations” and in joint action against externally fueled separatist tendencies. He stressed that the parties do not accept gross external interference in the affairs of the region, especially if this is done through the use of military force.

Lavrov called the cooperation of the security services of the four countries in the normalization of Syrian-Turkish relations useful and successful. He recalled that on April 25, Russia, Syria and Turkey held a second meeting in Moscow - then again represented by the defense ministers - and now Iran has joined them at the foreign ministerial meeting.

According to the host, the normalization between Damascus and Ankara “has a tangible positive impact not only on the situation around Syria, but also on the general atmosphere in the entire Middle East region.” He emphasized that the Russian side is also making a significant contribution to the restoration of relations between Syria and its neighbors. Lavrov also wished Turkey success in holding the presidential and parliamentary elections on Sunday.

TASS recalled that the process of normalizing relations between Ankara and Damascus began on December 28 last year with consultations in Moscow between the Russian, Syrian and Turkish defense ministers. An agreement was reached there to establish a joint trilateral commission. This was followed by a meeting at the level of foreign ministers, the agenda of which included preparations for talks between Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Syrian President Bashar al-Assad. Later, it was announced that Iran would also join the talks.

The four countries held professional consultations at the level of deputy foreign ministers in the Russian capital in early April.

Erdogan told reporters on December 15 that he had proposed to Russian President Vladimir Putin to hold a trilateral meeting with the Syrian

president. The summit, the Turkish leader said, should be preceded by special meetings at the level of intelligence, defense and foreign ministers.

Relations between Ankara and Damascus have deteriorated sharply since the start of the Syrian uprising and civil war in 2011. Turkey has been flooded with Syrian refugees and diplomatic relations between the two countries have been severed. Ankara has deployed troops to Syria.